regime again)'. Expectedly, it highlighted the new touch of grandeur and scale at the Hindu pilgrimage sites in Ayodhya, Varanasi, Prayagraj and Mathura, besides a host of welfare measures and development projects that the Adityanath government initiated or executed.

IMPORTANTLY, IN SEVERAL SCENES in the campaign video, Adityanath appears along with the prime minister. This includes the now-famous photo of Modi placing his hand paternally on Adityanath's shoulder, signaling his full backing for the CM to silence his doubters. After the song played out, state BJP president Swatantra Dev Singh waxed eloquent about the state government's achievements—the phrase "Yogi Sarkar" was a conspicuous leitmotif. All the signs pointed to just how important Adityanath had become to the party's poll campaign, along with Modi and Amit Shah—the architects of the BJP's landslide win here in 2017.

That is a remarkable turnaround. Five years ago, when Adityanath emerged as the BJP's surprise choice for chief minister in India's largest state, many were sceptical about his ability to stay the course. Though he was a five-time MP—indeed, even the youngest of the 12th Lok Sabha at 26 years of age—he had never held a ministerial office either at the Centre or in the state. His managerial experience had been limited to being head of a monastic order that oversaw the famed Shri Gorakhnath Math in Gorakhpur, on the northeastern fringe of UP, bordering Nepal, where the Nathpanthi footprint extends. Adityanath also ran a radical youth outfit called the Hindu Yuva Vahini that aggressively propagated Hindutva and often derided the BJP for plying a softer version of the saffron agenda.

When the BJP won a phenomenal 312 out of the 403 seats in the 2017 state assembly election and returned

BATTLE STRATEGIES

BJP

Yogi Adityanath

STRENGTHS

- A strong CM candidate with assured support from traditional Hindutva voters
- The BJP's organisational skill–booth-level microplanning–and its strong IT cell. Implementation of welfare schemes for the poor

CHALLENGES

- Soaring inflation, unemployment and the perception of being 'anti-Brahmin'. The fallout of the farmers' agitation
- The challenge of winning non-Yadav OBC voters

ALLIANCE PARTNERS

- **Apna Dal (S):** Led by central minister Anupriya Patel, strong in east UP. Its focus is on Kurmi OBC voters–the second-most influential OBC caste in the state after the Yadavs
- **Nishad Party:** Led by Dr Sanjay Nishad, it focuses on Nishad and Mallah voters, who have a presence in Prayagraj, Varanasi and Jaunpur, among other areas

SP

Akhilesh Yadav

STRENGTHS

- Vote banks among Yadavs and Muslims and is wooing Brahmin and Dalit voters. Has alliances with non-Yadav OBCs
- Image of a youthful and energetic leader with a history of development work

CHALLENGES

- No star campaigner besides Akhilesh. There are also internal political feuds
- The BSP, Congress and AIMIM might split the minority vote

ALLIANCE PARTNERS

- **RLD:** Led by Jayant Chaudhary, focuses on Jats. Will play a role in west UP
- **Suheldev Bhartiya Samaj:** An MBC party, led by Om Prakash Rajbhar, based in east UP
- **Pragatisheel Samaj (L):** Led by Akhilesh's uncle Shivpal, unites Yadav clan
- **Others:** Mahan Dal, the Janwadi Party (Socialist) and the Apna Dal (Krishna Patel)

BSP

Mayawati

STRENGTHS

- Personal mass appeal and a solid vote bank. Having been chief minister four times, she also has a lot of experience in managing a state

CHALLENGES

- Other parties are also wooing the BSP's vote bank: Dalits. The party is missing on the ground, and has also lost more than half its MLAs

ALLIANCE PARTNERS

None announced

INC

Priyanka Gandhi

STRENGTHS

- Personal mass appeal, with a strong presence on social media. Trying to build a new vote bank by giving 40 per cent of tickets to women

CHALLENGES

- The party has performed poorly in recent years, and has no fixed voter base to fall back on. Several senior leaders have also departed recently

ALLIANCE PARTNERS

None announced